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Russia-Ukraine war: Four Indian sailors among 10 killed as missile hits ship

Shubhajit Roy & Shaju Philip
New Delhi,
Thiruvananthapuram,
July 20



IN THE first deaths of Indian seafarers in the Russia-Ukraine war, four Indians were among 10 killed in a Russian missile strike on a merchant vessel departing Ukraine's southern port of Odesa on Sunday.

India was quick to condemn the attack, without directly blaming Russia.

According to the Ukrainian Air Force, Russian forces launched three Kh-59/Kh-69 cruise missiles during the attack. One missile struck the starboard side of the *Golden Leo*, a Turkish-owned merchant vessel sailing under the flag of Guinea-Bissau, igniting a fire.

“On the evening of 19 July 2026, the vessel *MV Golden Leo* was attacked while departing the port of Odesa. At the time of the incident, there were 17 crew

Grain carrier *MV Golden Leo* after it was hit by a Russian missile in the Black Sea close to Odesa, Ukraine, Sunday. AP

THE WORLD PAGE 13

IRAN WAR: HOW THIS OPEN NEW FRONT ON SAUDI ARABIA

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Indus Waters Treaty: Govt focus on Chenab projects, renegotiation

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, July 20

A YEAR after India put the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) "in abeyance" following the Pahalgam terror attack, it is pushing for speedy development of hydropower projects on the Chenab with a combined capacity of over 5,000 megawatts and renegotiation of the six-decade-old pact, government sources said on Monday.

and is ready to renegotiate it with Pakistan to make it more balanced. "IWT, in its present form, cannot function again," said a top source. Pakistan, sources said, has not shown any signs of ending cross-border terrorism against India — a precondition for resuming cooperation under the IWT.

For any future reactivation of the river water-sharing provisions, the treaty would need to be renegotiated in a modified format — a step that remains contingent on Islamabad

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● LATE GOAL GIVES SPAIN WORLD TITLE, LEAVES ARGENTINA DISTRAUGHT

As curtains fall, Spain have final say: 'Huge feeling of liberation'



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 20

A SWARM of raging red shirts piled over Ferran Torres when the final whistle blew at the MetLife Stadium, crowning Spain as the World Champions for the second time in their history. Torres's goal in the 106th minute, which decided a turgid and



Spain's Ferran Torres lifts the trophy with teammates. REUTERS

combative 1-0 final win bereft of dramatic twists that defined the tournament, would be as immortalised as Andres Iniesta's extra-time winner in 2010.

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Treaty

permanently halting its support for terrorism directed against India, sources said.

The Indian Express has learnt that Delhi's key priority is the speedy completion of hydro-power projects on the Chenab -- 1,856 MW Sawalkote Hydroelectric Project, 1,000 MW Pakal Dul Project, 850 MW Ratle Project, 624 MW Kiru Project, and 540 MW Kwar Project.

While the Kiru and Pakal projects are expected to be completed by the end of this year, the remaining are expected to be completed in the next two-three years, sources said.

These projects are critical for India's clean energy transition,

grid stability and regional development, and will substantially enhance India's hydropower capacity while enabling the fuller utilisation of its legitimate rights under the Indus basin, said sources. "Together with accelerated hydropower development and modern basin management, these initiatives will ensure that India's legitimate share of the Indus waters is utilised efficiently, sustainably and in accordance with its long-term developmental, water security and clean energy objectives," sources said.

Putting the Indian approach in context, since Pakistan has been trying to mobilise global opinion in its favour, sources said the IWT was negotiated and implemented in a spirit of goodwill, friendship and peaceful co-

existence. "Like any enduring international arrangement, it depended not merely on legal obligations but on mutual trust, reciprocity and good faith. For over six decades, India honoured both the letter and spirit of the treaty, maintaining uninterrupted implementation even during wars, military crises and prolonged periods of bilateral hostility," said sources.

Pakistan, however, simultaneously pursued a sustained policy of cross-border terrorism against India, added the sources. "Such conduct has fundamentally destroyed the atmosphere of trust necessary for cooperative implementation of the treaty. Agreements of this nature cannot remain insulated from persistent acts of hostility, terrorism," the sources said.

Russia-Ukraine war

said in a statement.

“As per information available, four Indian nationals have tragically lost their lives, while one is hospitalised in a critical condition. Our Mission in Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation and is making every effort to extend all possible assistance to those affected. We extend our deepest condolences to the families of the deceased Indian nationals and wish the injured Indian national a speedy and full recovery,” it said.

"India condemns such attacks and reiterates that targeting commercial shipping and endangering innocent civilian crew members, or otherwise impeding freedom of navigation and commerce, is deplorable and should be avoided," the MEA said.

While the Centre is yet to release the names of the dead, one of the sailors has been identified as Akhil Joyan, 26, a resident of Kasaragod district in Kerala. Family sources said they were contacted by the shipping firm. An official communication from the Chief Minister's Office said the NORKA (Non-resident Keralites Affairs Department) has been entrusted to get in touch with the MEA and Russian consulate for further details.

According to family sources, Akhil was the only son of Joyan, a merchant, and Saly, a collection agent at the postal depart-

ment. He joined the shipping industry as a mariner after completing a course in nautical science from Chennai, and had been working on the ship for the last six years.

"Last month, he visited his parents and his wedding was fixed. Akhil was planning to sign off from this ship by the end of this month. He wanted to move to another firm," said a family source.

The Ukrainian Sea Ports Authority (USPA) said the bulk carrier had aboard 17 crew members from Syria and India, as well as a Ukrainian port pilot, when it was hit shortly after departing Odesa with a cargo of corn. The strike killed 10 people, including the 66-year-old Ukrainian pilot and nine foreign crew members.

While there have been deaths of Indian seafarers in the US-Iran war in West Asia in the last four-and-a-half months, this is the first time that Indian sailors have been victims in the now four-and-a-half-year-old war between Russia and Ukraine.

Ukraine's Acting Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said the attack came just hours after Russia's overnight missile and drone assault on Kyiv. "While the world is still responding to Russia's brutal overnight attack on Kyiv, Moscow continues its campaign of terror throughout the day," Sybiha wrote on social media.

World Cup

He rose from the heap, exhausted with emotion, eyes shining with tears of inexpressible joy, hair dishevelled, the sleeves of his shirt torn, and gasped for breath.

Torres tried to evade the broadcasters' eyes but he could not. "In the end, the goal belongs to 47 million people, not me, nor do we 26 players here. Destiny was written today, we were going to win," he said. He called the goal "liberation". "It's a huge feeling of liberation. I've been criticised a lot during this World Cup but destiny was written, and I thank God, who always gives me strength to continue. Things come to those who deserve them," he said. It was his first goal of the tournament, and the

only that perhaps would matter
to him for the rest of his life.

After the final whistle, he was momentarily distracted by the melee near Spain's dugout. Argentina's Nahuel Molina and Spain's Rodri sparked a war of words before Rodri's teammate Eric Garcia intervened and pushed Molina away. From nowhere butted in Argentina's Leandro Paredes and tried to clutch Garcia's throat. Spain's Gavi entered the scuffle and nudged Paredes, which provoked Thiago Almada who pinned Gavi to the floor. The referee rifled in and brandished the brawler-in-chief Paredes a red card, before members from both teams dragged their players away. The match had been simmering on boiling point ever since Enzo Fernandez's second-half red card. Paredes might not care, because the pain he was

suffering was more bitter.

From Torres and the ecstatic Spanish players, with Lamine Yamal sprawled on the ground, wiping the tears with his palms, the eyes of the arena wandered to Lionel Messi, on the verge of tears, hands on his chin. Spain did not forget Messi in his moment of despair. Rodri hugged him; Pedri shook his hands. It would be the last that the grand-est stage had seen of its grandest player, but when an era ends, another begins. Torres's strike was the siren of Spain's domination in the years to come. It would remain a metaphor for the Spanish dynasty. It was inevitable and deserving, for Spain was the tournament's insurpassable team.

The moment of Torres's goal would seem blurry yet clear. It came without being accompanied by theatre or drama. The

electronic clock blinked 105, the red digits blinking. The scorching sun mellowed; the second half of the extra time had begun with the brimming possibility of a penalty shootout, which the turgid final deserved, but perhaps not Spain, with the utter domination of the game.

Rejuvenated after the break, Spain instantly dashed forward. From the right flank, Yamal skipped with the ball and passed to Pedro Porro, who pinged a speculative shot towards Nico Williams to the far post. The ball seemed over-hit, perhaps it was, but Williams beat an on-rushing Emi Martínez to the ball and headed it backwards to the unmanned Ferran Torres. The Spanish forward had time and space to gather, compose and leather the ball past Martínez, sending Spain to raptures, and Argentina to the gorge of misery.

and saving the match from the cruelty of a penalty shoot out.

Martínez's injudiciousness to march out of his lines would be reciprocated. But Argentina would feel the wheels of misfortune crushing them in the form of Gio Simeone, who was tracking Torres, pulling a muscle on the edge of the area.

The next 15 minutes with 10 men was arduous for Argentina. But they threw everything they could, men, ideas, and emotions. In the stage of the extra time, they came closes twice, but were brutally denied by Spain's defenders. Spain were not to be bullied or badgered, as they huffed and hagged every advance of Argentina. Even Messi stood helpless, curl and whisp eluding his deliveries, his movements restrained by a silken midfielder operating at the peak of his prowess. If even

Messi could not alter the destiny of the afternoon, perhaps nothing could.

The goal was in tune with the game's tempo. The more they watch were on, the more it seemed like it would be defined by a singular piece of action, one of burst of ingenuity or fortune, one act of indiscretion or genius, one mad or inspired moment. But the game couldn't shake off its afflictions with dullness. In normal time, Spain had nineteen shots on goal, none from their sweet spot. At the other end, Argentina did not even have an attempt on goal in normal time.

A penalty shootout seemed inevitable, but for Torres's whipper-snapper strike. The goal of his life; the siren of the second Spanish dynasty; and perhaps the last act of the greatest footballer that had walked on the earth.

Over 1.88 lakh ha of forest land diverted in 10 yrs

Between April 1, 2016 and March 31, 2026, an area of more than 1.88 lakh hectares of forest land had been diverted under the Van (Sanrakshan Evam Samvardhan) Adhiniyam, 1980, including industrial projects, Union MoS for Environment Kirti Vardhan Singh said in a written reply to a question Monday. He said that total forest & tree cover has increased to 8,27,357.95 sq km, according to the India State of Forest Report 2023. In a different written reply, Singh also told LS that for FY 2025-26, average time for environmental clearance was 57 days against statutory timelines of 105 days prescribed in EIA Notification, 2006. PTI

HC recalls gag order on *The Wire* for future articles against former chief secretary

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 20

THE DELHI High Court on Monday recalled a gag order on future publications by digital news platform *The Wire* and a journalist on former Delhi chief secretary Naresh Kumar.

“There is no conceivable way, whether in fact or in law, by which it can be presumed that what an author or publisher is proposing to publish would be defamatory, even going by any past publication that may have been made by the author/publisher,” the High Court held.

In November 2023, Kumar had moved the HC with a defamation suit after *The Wire* published a news report alleging that his son was linked to a case of over-valuation of land, reported by journalist Meetu Jain. The article had also reportedly recorded Kumar’s assertion that “there is no conflict of interest on his part” in the alleged land deal. Kumar, though, alleged that “certain disgruntled elements...” had circulated the allegedly false and fabricated complaints against him.

Justice Anup Jairam Bhambhani, while recalling the gag, observed that “to assume that what someone may publish would be defamatory, is egregiously hypothetical and presumptive; and therefore cannot be the basis of a court injunction...”

NHAI launches digital ‘local pass’ for residents in 20-km radius of toll plazas

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, July 20

IN A push for a barrier-less tolling system, the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) has launched a digital “local pass” for residents in the 20-km radius of toll plazas on the Rajmargyatra app.

On June 17, *The India Express* had reported that the government was planning to introduce this pass by July. The move came after implementation of the Multi-lane free flow (MLFF) tolling or barrier-less tolling system in different toll plazas. In this system, commuters do not have to stop to

pay the toll.

The eligibility for the local pass will be established based on the VAHAN details, which will retrieve a commuter’s address, vehicle number and linked FASTag.

The first facility of digital local toll pass has been introduced at the Mundka-Bakkarwala toll plaza on Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) in Delhi and will be rolled out at other toll plazas across the country in the coming months, said NHAI. The MLFF system at the Mundka-Bakkarwala toll plaza was made operational on May 11.

“Residents living within a 20 km radius of an eligible toll

plaza will be able to purchase a ‘local pass’ digitally through Rajmargyatra mobile app, allowing unlimited travel through the respective toll plaza during the month,” said the NHAI.

Earlier, commuters were required to visit the toll plaza and submit supporting documents to establish their eligibility. This process can now be done digitally in a few minutes, said NHAI.

Officials said the “local pass” was introduced since among the violators who don’t pay the toll fees, residents in the 20-km radius constitute a significant share.

India, Moldova discuss UNSC reforms, fight against terror

Divya A
New Delhi, July 20

INDIA AND Moldova discussed reforms of multilateral organisations, including the UN Security Council, and cooperation in the fight against terrorism, as President Droupadi Murmu landed in Chisinau on her state visit to the country. Murmu is the first Indian head of state to visit the landlocked Eastern European country since the establishment of diplomatic relations in 1992.

The President held bilateral discussions with her Moldovan counterpart Maia Sandu, where the two leaders explored new avenues of cooperation in trade and investment, digital trans-



President Droupadi Murmu receives a ceremonial welcome from Moldovan counterpart Maia Sandu in Chisinau on Monday. PTI

formation, information technology, healthcare, pharmaceuticals, agriculture, education, culture and capacity building, according to the Min-

istry of External Affairs (MEA). Briefing the media, MEA’s Secretary (West) Sibi George said, “They also discussed cooperation in (the) fight against ter-

E. EXPLAINED

The Outreach

India’s outreach to Eastern Europe seeks to diversify its European engagement beyond major Western powers such as France and Germany. Over the next few days, President Murmu will also be visiting North Macedonia and Romania.

rorism. Both sides discussed (the) importance of reforms of multilateral organisations, including the UNSC.”

As a special gesture of friend-

ship, Murmu presented a bust of Mahatma Gandhi to President Sandu. The President laid a wreath at the Monument of Stefan cel Mare si Sfânt (Stephen the Great), paying tribute to one of Moldova’s most revered national figures.

As part of her day-long visit, Murmu met Igor Grosu, speaker of the Moldovan parliament, and interacted with members of the India-Moldova Parliamentary Friendship Group.

Later, both Presidents jointly addressed the India-Moldova Business Forum, which brought together leading business representatives from both countries to explore fresh opportunities in trade, investment, innovation and technology.



Anti-defection law needs drastic changes



DESH DEEPAK VERMA

AS PARLIAMENT'S Monsoon Session commences, the red carpets of the Rajya Sabha will have some different shadows cast upon them by MPs who originally belonged to one shade of political party but now belong to another. The arithmetic of the House will also change because of these large-scale defections and realignments.

The Opposition predictably attributes these defections to horse-trading, political inducements and the fear of investigative agencies. The ruling party, on the other hand, argues that many legislators have merely chosen to free themselves from autocratic or family-centric political organisations. There may be elements of truth in both narratives.

Amid this exchange of accusations and counter-accusations, a more fundamental issue gets overlooked — the continuing failure of India's anti-defection law to contain the very political opportunism it was enacted to curb.

The anti-defection law was introduced through the Fifty-second Constitutional Amendment in 1985 by incorporating the Tenth Schedule into the Constitution. Its principal objective was to curb the political instability caused by frequent defections.

The Ninety-first Constitutional Amendment of 2003 further tightened the law by abolishing the exemption from disqualification for a bloc comprising at least one-third of the members of a legislature party. Thereafter, only a merger supported by at least two-thirds of the members of a legislature party remained eligible for this exemption.

The experience of implementing the anti-defection law, even after these amendments, has been far from satisfactory. Under the Tenth Schedule, the authority to decide disqualification petitions rests with the presiding officers of the respective Houses — the Speaker in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies, and the Chairmen in the Rajya Sabha and Legislative Councils. While the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha is mandated to resign from his or her parent party, this is not obligatory for the Speakers. This arrangement, rightly or wrongly, inevitably gives rise to questions about institutional im-

partiality. Presiding officers have delayed decisions on disqualification petitions for months and years, and at times, for the entire tenure of the House. The Supreme Court has repeatedly observed that such petitions should ordinarily be decided within three months, and some Chairmen of the Rajya Sabha have echoed the same expectation. Yet deliberate procedural delays have often rendered the law ineffective.

Paradoxically, the stricter provisions have also not eliminated defections. Instead, political efforts now focus on engineering defections on a larger scale, enough to satisfy the two-thirds requirement for a merger. The phenomenon has now become more organised, accompanied by greater political bargaining and inducements. Thus, the anti-defection law has, in practice, become an instrument for escalating defections rather than preventing them.

What is the solution? It needs some drastic and fundamental constitutional changes. We would need a law to automatically end, on the date of resignation, the tenure of any elected representative who resigns from the political party on whose ticket he or she was elected. The individual could seek a fresh mandate, and if he or she enjoys public support independent of party affiliation, there should be no difficulty in securing re-election — either as an Independent candidate or as another party's nominee, in the vacated seat or any other. This would shift the ultimate authority to decide a defecting legislator's right to continue in the House from party managers and presiding officers to the electorate.

Critics may argue that such a provision would discourage genuine dissent within political parties and inhibit independent thinking. That concern, however, appears overstated. Legislators would remain entirely free to disagree with their party, resign from it and seek a fresh mandate. What the amendment would discourage is not dissent but the retention of an elected office after abandoning the political platform on which that office was secured.

The writer is former secretary general, Rajya Sabha, Parliament of India

Managing the temple, a case for guardrails



PALLAV SHISHODIA

THE VALLABH Sampraday worships Lord Krishna as a joyous and playful deity, with Tilkayat, *ji* as its supreme head. In the 1950s, there were controversies due to large-scale bungling in the properties of the sect's main temple, one of the richest, in Nathdwara.

Its takeover by the state was challenged without success before the Supreme Court, which negated the religious right claimed by Tilkayat, *ji* to manage this temple and its assets, holding it to be a secular matter. The temple board, created by statute to manage its temporal affairs, except matters of faith, is a unique blend of the spiritual lineage, state supervision and efforts of prominent devotees like the Ambanis. The Ram Janmabhoomi temple in Ayodhya was built with state support but without any state oversight. The latter is an imperative, not a panacea, to ensure transparency, accountability and institutional integrity.

The movement for the temple at Ayodhya and its construction were a balm to hurt Hindu sentiments. What has now emerged is alleged loot from land deals, construction contracts and *chaddavas*, which include large amounts of gold, silver and cash. Denials apart, there are several structural impediments to the full magnitude of the irregularities coming out in the public domain.

There is a fairly evolved legal framework to manage the spiritual, temporal and secular affairs of the thousands of religious places, small and large, in India. Our Constitution guarantees the "right to freely profess, practice and propagate religion" subject to public order, morality, and health. The state can make laws only to regulate secular activities and reform religion. The guaranteed rights of denominations to establish and maintain religious institutions, manage their own affairs, own and administer properties are enunciated in several cases. A slew of temple boards, charity commissioners or Devasthan departments oversee the management of secular activities, while religious aspects are governed by the religious denominations. Be it a dargah, gurdwara or any other religious institution, this is the broad pattern. This module, with local variations, also serves the economies of towns, charitable and educational institutions, hospitals, and several other activities around religious institutions. For instance, the annual sale in public auction of the hair tonsured at the Tirupati temple comes to about 500 mt, valued at around Rs 200 crore. It has over 600 laddoo-makers protected by labour laws. The Guruvayur temple has regulations to shelter elephants gifted by devotees. About 1,00,000 people on weekdays and an even greater number on weekends partake in the langar at the Golden Temple. All of this is managed by their respective statutory bodies.

Imagine all these activities with trustees, priests and managers having complete freedom with no state-mandated guardrails. The Ram Mandir at Ayodhya suffers from a structural deficit, with or without a CEO. There are no reasons in the public domain why the formation of a private trust was directed, without a temple board. Does the state have no role in a temple with such an inflow of devotees and donations? In a quest to save the larger faith in Ram, the alleged loot is being underplayed as a small con job. The state cannot wish it away as an internal matter of a private trust. It must stem this rot to restore the hurt faith of millions.

The writer is a senior advocate

We would need a law to automatically end, on the date of resignation, the tenure of any elected representative who resigns from the political party on whose ticket he or she was elected

A slew of temple boards, charity commissioners or Devasthan departments oversee the management of secular activities, while religious aspects are governed by the religious denominations

India all set to get its first dengue vaccine

Anuradha Mascarenhas
Pune, July 20

INDIA IS all set to get its first dengue vaccine.

The Drug Controller General of India (DCGI) has approved Japanese company Takeda Biopharmaceuticals India's dengue vaccine, Qdenga — making it the first such vaccine to be greenlighted in the country. The vaccine is designed to protect against all four dengue virus strains (DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4) and can be administered regardless of prior dengue exposure, the company said. It also does not require pre-vaccination testing, it added.

Administered subcutaneously, the vaccine comes as a two-dose regimen of 0.5 ml each given three months apart. Takeda has entered into a manufacturing partnership with Hyderabad-based Biological E to produce up to 50 million doses annually. In an official statement issued on Monday, Dr Ma-

Nayak, head of intercontinental markets for Takeda, said, "Dengue is a growing public health challenge and India needs sustained, evidence-based prevention."

He said, "The latest seven-year data for Qdenga show continued protection against dengue infection and hospitalisation across all four

E.

Key breakthrough in public health

The approval comes at a critical time for public health, with reported cases in India increasing 11-fold over the past two decades. India continues to account for nearly 1/3rd of the global burden of dengue – a mosquito-borne viral disease with prevalence in over 125 countries

serotypes -- an important milestone for communities and health systems."

In reply to an email query by *The Indian Express* on the vaccine's pricing, Dr Nayak said, "Takeda is pleased that QDenga has received Market Authorization in India. We are committed to supporting broad, equitable, timely and sustainable access at a cost that reflects the vaccine's value and potential health, societal and economic benefits. Pricing and availability will be communicated once local processes are complete."

Since its launch in 2022, Qdenga has been approved in 43 countries, with more than 32 million doses distributed globally.

Dr Goh Choo Beng, Takeda's medical affairs head for South-east Asia and India Cluster, said, "India carries a substantial dengue burden, and all four dengue virus serotypes have been documented as co-circulating in several regions. The approval represents an important step in strengthening India's comprehensive approach to dengue prevention, alongside vector control, surveillance, community awareness and other public health measures."

Assam floods: 5 dead, thousands evacuated, over 3.6 lakh affected

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, July 20

FIVE PEOPLE died and over 3.6 lakh were affected after incessant rain led to flooding in Assam.

Eastern Assam was particularly affected as five rivers were flowing above the danger level on Monday.

Six teams of the National Disaster Response Force with 24 boats were deployed for rescue operations in Sivasagar and Charaideo districts, while another two teams with 10 boats were deployed in Jorhat district.

As of Monday evening, a total of 6,710 people were evacuated from affected areas by boats, of whom 5,526 are from Charaideo and 1,000 are from Jorhat.

Four people in Jorhat district died in the flooding on Monday, and another person died in Karbi Anglong.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma announced that the Assam government requested the Army and the Air Force to be on standby to support evacuation and rescue operations if necessary.

Prodip Kalita, a resident of the Nazira area in Sivasagar district, said his house was flooded and that the water was coming up to the chest level.

"It has been raining since



NDRF personnel conduct a rescue operation in a flood-affected area in Assam on Monday. ANI

Sunday morning, and the paddy fields around our house started filling up with water. But we thought that it would drain away after some time once the rain stopped. However, it rained throughout till late afternoon, and then we heard that the Dikhow river had swelled up. Within no time, the water from the river swelled over and reached our house," he said.

According to the Assam Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), the Dikhow river at Sivasagar was flowing at "extreme flood situation" as of 9 am on Monday, flowing at 2.10 metres above its "danger level" of 92.4 metres. At noon, it announced that another river, the Dhansiri

in Golaghat district, was flowing at “severe flood situation”. Three other rivers, the Burhidihing in Khowang, the Disang in Nganglamuraghat and the Brahmaputra in Neamatighat, were also flowing “above danger level”.

Announcing efforts to address the overflowing rivers, the Assam government said in a statement, "Sand-filled bags are being laid along the Dikhow embankment, pipping at the Disang embankment in Baruahchuk is being addressed, Type-B geobags are being dumped at Santipur to restore the Disang riverbank and flood fighting works continue at the Jhanji embankment NArkonnar Bailing Gaon."

ment in and around slopes, high altitudes and hilly areas for the period until the

buried their house in the upper reaches of Loran in Poonch district, while three people were

ernment has also suspended the Amarnath Yatra from both the Baltal and Chandanwari routes.



Britain's King Charles III greets Labour Party leader Andy Burnham during an audience at Buckingham Palace in London on Monday. AP

New PM of Britain pledges to end years of political instability

Burnham assures Trump on defence, security, West Asia

Reuters
London, July 20

ANDY BURNHAM became Britain's seventh prime minister in a decade on Monday, pledging to reshape its politics to deliver a new economic model and revive a nation "fed up" with a revolving door of leaders.

In front of dozens of supporters outside his new office and residence at 10 Downing Street, Burnham said politicians had failed to bring the stability needed to raise living standards, something he said he would change.

Speaking without notes, Burnham said, "I know people at home are fed up with politics. I hear you, and I want to be honest with you, we have not been good enough and we need to be better." Burnham pledged to use his premiership as a "circuit-breaker for Britain."

Just over an hour after his predecessor Keir Starmer made

Healey new UK Chancellor, Ed Miliband is Foreign Secy

London: Former Defence Secretary John Healey has been named as the Chancellor of the Exchequer and Ed Miliband as the new Foreign Secretary under new PM Andy Burnham, the UK government said on Monday.

REUTERS

his farewell speech to say "my work is done", the 56-year-old former Greater Manchester mayor entered Downing Street.

In one of his first calls with a foreign leader, Burnham assured US President Donald Trump that London would be committed to defence and security and would help support the safe reopening of the Strait of Hormuz.

"The PM... underlined his commitment to defence and security and said ensuring the security of the UK and its allies was at the top of his agenda," a spokesperson said.

Veteran Hamas official Khalil al-Hayya named group's leader

Reuters
July 20

KHALIL AL-Hayya, a senior Hamas official who survived an Israeli raid on Qatar in September last year and who is seen as having good ties with Iran, was named on Monday as the leader of the Palestinian militant group.

Hayya, who lost a son in the Gaza conflict and two sons in previous wars, has been based with other Hamas leaders in Doha. He has become increasingly influential in the group as

other top Hamas officials have been killed in Israeli strikes, among them Ismail Haniyeh on a visit to Iran and Yahya Sinwar in the Gaza Strip.

Hayya was at the heart of ceasefire talks throughout the Gaza war that erupted when Hamas launched a surprise attack on Israel on October 7, 2023, prompting a sweeping Israeli offensive that has flattened much of the enclave since then.

He took part in indirect talks with Israel that culminated in a US-brokered ceasefire in October 2025 that halted major



Khalil al-Hayya

fighting in Gaza, although Israel has continued attacks on Hamas and other militants who it says pose an imminent threat.

An earlier ceasefire initiative had been on the agenda for discussion between the 64-year-old and other Hamas leaders when they were targeted in Israel's September 9 attack on Doha, in which six people were killed but no top Hamas officials.

Hayya, widely seen as the group's most influential figure abroad since Haniyeh was killed by Israel in Iran in July 2024, is part of a five-man leadership council based in Qatar that has led Hamas since Yahya Sinwar, the mastermind of the October 2023 attacks, was killed last year.

Hailing from the Gaza Strip, Hayya is a veteran member of the Islamist group. Regarded as having good ties with Iran, a vital source of arms and finance for Hamas, he has been closely involved in the group's efforts to broker several truces with Israel, playing a key role in ending a 2014 conflict and again in attempts to secure an end to the current Gaza war.

Hayya has been part of Hamas since it was set up in 1987.

In the early 1980s, he joined the Muslim Brotherhood, the Sunni Islamist movement from

which Hamas emerged, along with Haniyeh and Sinwar, Hamas sources say. In Gaza, he was detained several times by Israel. In 2007, an Israeli airstrike hit his family home in Gaza City killing several relatives. In 2008, his son Hamza was killed by an Israeli airstrike.

Hayya left Gaza several years ago, serving as a Hamas point person for ties with the Arab and Islamic worlds and basing himself in Qatar. He accompanied Haniyeh to Tehran for the visit in July during which Haniyeh was assassinated.



• **LAW**

Staging a protest: Rights, restrictions in the law

• **ENERGY**

Despite record solar adoption, why Kerala is facing power cuts

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 20

KERALA IS among India's leading states when it comes to household adoption of rooftop solar panels under the PM Surya Ghar Yojana. While the scheme's success has been uneven nationwide, Kerala ranks fourth in installed capacity, ahead of several big states.

Yet, this is at the heart of the challenge in meeting its power demand. This sounds counterintuitive — shouldn't more rooftop solar panels ease electricity supply?

The answer is not so straightforward.

Solar success story

Data shows Kerala's solar power installed capacity touched 2,508 megawatts (MW) by the end of May 2026. The vast majority of this — 2,036 MW — is from rooftop panels.

Under the scheme, Kerala has 2.96 lakh installations covering 3,03,531 households, with an installed capacity of 1,150 MW. Meanwhile, neighbouring Karnataka has only 22,383 installations covering 33,843 households, with an installed capacity of 91 MW.

The share of solar power as a whole is more than 50% of the state's total installed capacity from all sources. This proportion is even better than the all-India share of solar power in the overall power generation mix: 150 GW of the total installed capacity of 532 GW.

• **DAILY DEMAND**

Although traditionally dependent on hydroelectricity, 83% of Kerala's daily power demand is now met by purchases from power exchanges.

● Daily average consumption is 88.45 million units, of which total domestic generation from hydel, wind and solar comes to 15 million units.

and the shortage of power supply at night.

This mismatch is not a Kerala problem alone. India's power grid has been facing its greatest strain at night time. This, however, is more a function of supply failing to even meet the relatively reduced night-time demand, rather than demand rising during those hours. In Kerala, the latter is the key problem — demand rises at night.

The power produced from solar plants during the day is exported to the low-tension power distribution grid. But excessive feeding of solar power to the grid during the day, when consumption is low, increases the voltage in the system. This increases the chances of electrical appliances and transformers getting damaged.

So, when power supply declines in the national market at night, Kerala's electricity utility is forced to buy it at higher prices to meet its rising demand.

As the share of renewable power sources increases, so does the mismatch between when electricity is generated and when it is needed. The answer is storage.

The state has lined up a battery energy storage system to "store" the solar power produced during the day — rather than pumping it back into the grid. This will ensure that the power can be used during the peak nighttime hours.

• **POLICY**

What EPFO 3.0 proposes: Pension cover for all, social security for gig workers

Ravi Dutta Mishra & Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, July 20

A UNIVERSAL pension cover for all workers with option of either annuity or systematic withdrawal plan, first-time social security contributions for unorganised sector workers including gig and platform workers, an upgradation of tech ecosystem to incorporate core banking solution (CBS) — these are some of the key changes being planned by the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) as part of its 3.0 reforms phase.

The EPFO is set to move towards this through a CBS-enabled tech platform, which has been seen as necessary to help it navigate payments for social security schemes covering over 60 crore workers, out of which over three-quarters are in the unorganised sector, with limited or no pension coverage.

Target Retirement Sum

The new pension cover will have a defined contribution framework with con-

tributions from multiple sources including workers themselves, employers, government co-contributions for lower-income workers, aggregators in the case of gig and platform workers, and corporate social responsibility (CSR) or third-party funds. This is the first time that the EPFO is considering such forms of contributions or withdrawals at the time of retirement: presently, it only allows advance claims or partial withdrawals for certain categories such as education, illness, housing, and marriage during the membership tenure, or a lumpsum final settlement at the time of retirement.

The contributions will accumulate over time, and be invested in government-backed securities, with annual crediting of interest, giving two options for conversion of the "Target Retirement Sum (TRS)" at the time of retirement — pension based on prevailing annuity and interest rates, or a systematic withdrawal plan.

"Till the time of retirement, it will operate like PF, you keep on accumulating," an official told *The Indian Express*.

The system will compute the proposed TRS dynamically based on the member's chosen pension goal and expected retirement age. Members will have personalised dashboards showing total contributions, real-time corpus status, and progress towards the TRS for applicable schemes. The system will project the required contribution amount and frequency to achieve the declared TRS.

Inflation-linked simulation

Global models are being studied to incorporate similar features such as that of Singapore, which has a deferred annuity scheme that sets aside savings not just for retirement but also for housing and healthcare. Singapore's social security scheme relies not just on individual contributions for the retirement income as apart from a contribution of 20% of the salary, individual efforts are supplemented by employers, loved ones, and the government.

The flexibility to decide the amount for pension payouts, or the drawdown, will be



Protesters near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Monday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

proach internationally. Addressing the UN Human Rights Council in Geneva in 2021, India's representative said that while peaceful assembly is a cherished constitutional right, the government must also balance it with its obligation to protect public order and the right to life.

How has Section 163 actually been used?

Although Section 163 is most commonly associated with prohibiting protests, empirical evidence suggests that protest-related restrictions form only a small fraction of its use in Delhi.

A study published in March 2023 by advocates Vrinda Bhandari, Abhinav Sekhri, Natasha Maheshwari and Madhav Aggarwal examined around 5,400 Section 144 orders issued across Delhi between January 2021 and 2022. It found that roughly only 1.5% of orders related to prohibited unlawful assemblies, while five of Delhi's 18 police districts did not issue a single assembly-related order during the period. The re-

Emergency power

The Supreme Court upheld the validity of the erstwhile Section 144 of the CrPC as an emergency power.

● But the court stressed that it could not become a permanent mechanism to prohibit protests.

Burnham's philosophy

● Burnham's return to Westminster has been attributed to his emerging economic philosophy dubbed "Manchesterism".

● This concept champions aggressive state-level intervention to promote regional growth and devolution of power.



Britain's new PM Andy Burnham. AP

"disgraceful" earned him the moniker "King of the North" while cementing his position as a leader looking out for smaller, forgotten communities.

Burnham also went on to establish the Bee Network, which was a public transport overhaul that pioneered an affordable, unified and fully integrated system outside of London. His attempts were well-received — visible in his re-election in 2021 and 2024, where he won over 60% of the vote.

Return to Westminster

Today, Burnham's return has been at-

The right to protest is protected under Article 19(1)(a) and Article 19(1)(b) of the Constitution. This right, however, is not absolute and may be regulated

bly is an essential element of any democratic system. At the root of this concept lie the citizens' right to meet face to face with others for the discussion of their ideas and problems — religious, political, economic or social." The court added, "It is doubtless true that the State or local authority can regulate its property in order to serve its public purposes... But there is a constitutional difference between reasonable regulation and arbitrary exclusion."

The Court elaborated on these principles in *Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan v. Union of India* (2018). The case challenged the repeated issuance of Section 144 orders prohibiting public meetings, demonstrations and dharnas around Parliament House, North and South Block, Central Vista and adjoining areas without written permission.

The Supreme Court upheld the validity of Section 144 as an emergency power but stressed that it could not become a permanent mechanism to prohibit protests. It noted that although the orders formally required prior permission, authorities had effectively converted the permission requirement into a blanket ban by routinely refusing permission.

The judgment also dealt with an NGT order that had prohibited all protests along Jantar Mantar Road. Setting aside the blanket prohibition, the Court observed that "the solution was not to ban the demonstrations altogether" but to regulate them in a manner that balanced protesters' rights with the rights of local residents.

The SC directed authorities to frame guidelines governing protests, including regulating the number of participants, maintaining minimum distances from Parliament, the SC and other sensitive locations, prescribing time limits and prohibiting weapons such as firearms, lathis and swords. The ruling effectively reaffirmed Jantar Mantar as Delhi's designated protest site, while making clear that regulation must not become prohibition.

Two years later, in *Amit Sahni v Commissioner of Police* (2020), which arose from the Shaheen Bagh protests, the Supreme Court held that protests must be held in "identified areas" and protesters cannot block public roads and cause inconvenience to others.

"You cannot block public roads. There cannot be indefinite period of protest in such an area. If you want to protest, it has to be in an area identified for protest. You cannot create inconvenience for the people," the court said.

tributed to his emerging economic philosophy dubbed "Manchesterism". This concept champions aggressive state-level intervention to promote regional growth and devolution of power.

Former Ambassador to Belgium and the EU, Manjeev Singh Puri, told *The Indian Express*: "Labour might think that he is the man to galvanise them to be a party that can win the upcoming 2029 general elections." This power to galvanise was seen within a day of Burnham's win in Makerfield, amid Starmer's weakened position. "Fundamentally, Burnham also enjoys being on the right side of perception since Starmer reached a point after his 2024 landslide victory where Labour MPs didn't perceive him as the next general election leader," Puri said.

Burnham was the favourite early on after Starmer's exit, securing the votes of 379 of the 403 Labour MPs. Ideologically, he walks a factional tightrope, representative of the challenges Labour faces. He has advocated expanding council housing to appease the more left-leaning voters, while pledging himself as a 'pro-business' PM to reassure the centrist right.

‘RENEWABLES, DIGITAL INNOVATION TO LEAD NEXT GROWTH WAVE; AI WON’T RESULT IN JOB LOSSES’

‘FCNR(B) flows to peak in August, Sept; overall target achievable’

PUNJAB NATIONAL Bank Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer **Ashok Chandra** said the bank is on track to achieve the target of \$2.50 billion under the FCNR(B) scheme. “Most of the inflows across the industry are likely to come during the latter half of August and September, so I am optimistic that the overall banking target (of over \$50 billion) can be achieved,” he told **George Mathew** in an interview. Throughout the last financial year, he saw healthy growth in every quarter across retail, agriculture and MSME lending, and there is no point in mobilising excess liquidity if it cannot be deployed productively, Chandra said.

He said renewable energy is one of the sectors they have identified as a champion area, and ruled out any job losses due to AI introduction in banking. Edited excerpts:

Coming to the recent RBI measures on FCNR(B) deposits, how has been the response so far? Are inflows meeting your expectations? What do you expect over the next three months?

Yes, the response has been in line with our expectations. So far, we have mobilised around \$425 million.

We have guided the market that we intend to mobilise \$2.5 billion before September 30, and we are on track to achieve that target. In fact, we expect to reach it ahead of the schedule.

Has the higher cost of funds created challenges? Since depositors can also borrow overseas, has that affected mobilisation?

No, not at all. While the cost structure has increased, it has not created any significant issue for us. We have a large NRI customer base across several countries, and our teams are actively engaging with them. What has changed is the scale of our outreach. Earlier, we may have focused on a relatively small group of NRIs. Today, we are engaging with a much larger customer base. Our objective is to broaden our overseas deposit base rather than depend on a limited number of customers.

More broadly, do you believe the banking industry as a whole will be able to mobilise around \$50 billion under the scheme?

Yes, I believe it will. Most of the inflows across the industry are likely to come during the latter half of August and September, so I am optimistic that the overall target can be achieved.

Is there any significant switching by NRIs from NRE deposits to FCNR(B) deposits?

No, we are not seeing that. It would generally not be advantageous for customers to convert existing NRE deposits into FCNR(B) deposits at the current rates, as they would incur a loss in doing so. The scheme is more beneficial for customers bringing in fresh over-



EXPRESS
interview

ASHOK CHANDRA
MD AND CEO, PUNJAB NATIONAL BANK

seas deposits, and that is where we are seeing the inflows.

Credit growth has picked up significantly over the last few months. Which sectors are driving this growth? Do you expect the momentum to continue?

The retail, agriculture and MSME (RAM) segment has performed very well. Throughout the last financial year, we saw healthy growth in every quarter across retail, agriculture and MSME lending. The bank placed considerable focus on these segments during the last financial year. We conducted extensive outreach programmes across the country. The entire top management — including the MD and CEO, executive directors, chief general managers, general managers, and officials from the Head Office — visited the field. This created significant traction. Retail lending grew by 17.5%,

priority sector lending by 16.4%, and MSME lending by 19.8%, nearly 20%. Our corporate loan book also grew by around 10%. In fact, the underlying corporate portfolio grew by nearly 15-16%, but because we repriced and exited certain low-yield advances, the reported growth stands at about 10%. We continue to see strong traction in the corporate segment as well. Overall, the bank has performed well across all segments, and this momentum has continued into the current quarter.

On the corporate lending side, which sectors are generating strongest demand?

Renewable energy is one of the sectors we have identified as a champion area. We are growing faster than many players in the segment, with growth of around 30% in renewable energy financing. Apart from that, we’re

seeing healthy demand in infrastructure, particularly roads, data centres, agriculture-related businesses, trading activities, and engineering. During the last financial year, we sanctioned nearly Rs 4 lakh crore worth of corporate loans. Our lending is well diversified across sectors.

AI is being adopted rapidly across industries. Do you think it could lead to job losses in banking? How do you see it helping areas such as credit operations and risk management?

Our objective in adopting these digital tools is to improve the customer experience. Customer convenience remains our highest priority. These technologies will enable our employees to engage more effectively with customers and provide better service. At the same time, we will continue to upgrade the skills of our employees through training and reskilling so they can work effectively alongside these new technologies. The objective is to ensure that both our employees and our customers benefit from digital transformation.

So, are you saying AI will not result in job cuts?

No, we do not see AI leading to job losses. What AI will do is improve productivity, streamline processes, enhance the quality of our services and improve the quality of our data. These are the key benefits we expect from adopting these technologies. **FULL INTERVIEW ON**

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Hormuz crisis: Crude imports surge 60%; net oil, gas imports up 45%

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 20

INDIA’S CRUDE oil import bill surged by over 60% on a year-on-year (y-o-y) basis in the first quarter of the current financial year even as import volumes dipped slightly amid supply tightness and elevated prices due to the West Asia crisis and stifled energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz, as per provisional data from the petroleum ministry.

Similarly, liquefied natural gas (LNG) imports and petroleum product exports declined in volume terms, while rising in value. Overall, the country’s net oil and gas imports jumped 45% in value from year-ago levels, underscoring the adverse economic impact of the West Asia crisis on energy import-dependent India.

The country depends on imports to meet over 88% of its crude oil requirement and about half of its consumption of natural gas, which is imported as LNG, or super-chilled gas. Despite depending on imported oil and gas, it is a net exporter of petroleum products due to its massive oil refining capacity, while it also imports some petroleum products like liquefied petroleum gas (LPG).

Around 40% of India’s crude oil imports, 60% of its LNG imports, and a whopping 90% of its LPG imports came from West Asia through the strait. Apart from grappling with physical supply tightness due to the Strait of Hormuz crisis, the resultant surge in international prices forced India to import oil and gas at extremely high rates, as the country has been prioritising supply security over price considerations.

The June MoU between the US and Iran brought a sigh of relief for India and the global energy market, but the renewed

• West Asia war impacts energy bill

	APR-JUN FY26	APR-JUN FY27	CHANGE (%)
Oil imports (mn tn)	62.6	59.8	-4.5
Oil imports (\$ bn)	30.9	49.8	61.2
Petroleum pdt imports (mn tn)	12.2	7.1	-41.8
Petroleum pdt imports (\$ bn)	5.8	4.2	-27.6
LNG imports (mscm)	8396	7674	-8.6
LNG imports (\$ bn)	3.4	3.6	5.9
Petroleum pdt exports (mn tn)	15	11.3	-24.7
Petroleum pdt exports (\$ bn)	9.1	12.7	39.6
Net oil & gas imports (\$ bn)	30.9	44.9	45.3

SOURCE: PETROLEUM PLANNING AND ANALYSIS CELL (PPAC)

conflict in the Gulf following the pact’s effective collapse is emerging as a major concern as energy flows through the strait have crashed again after a short-lived three-week recovery.

Oil & gas trade math

According to latest provisional data released by the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC), crude oil imports in the June quarter rose 61.2% y-o-y to \$49.8 billion, even as import volumes declined 4.5% to 59.8 million tonnes (mt), or about 438 million barrels. This translates to about \$113 per barrel as the average landed price of imported crude oil in the June quarter, up from around \$67 per barrel in the corresponding quarter of last year.

The PPAC data shows that India’s dependence on imported oil in April-June was 89.1%, flat on a y-o-y basis.

As for LNG imports, while supplies declined 8.6% to 7,674 million standard cubic metres (mscm) in April-June from 8,396 mscm in the corresponding quarter of last year, the LNG import bill rose by almost 6% to \$3.6 billion, reflecting the spurt in prices.

Petroleum product imports declined almost 42% in volume terms to 7.1 mt, as supply of major petroleum products that India imports — like LPG — were impacted by the West Asia war. In value terms, the decline in petroleum product imports was relatively lower — down 27.6% to \$4.2 billion — due to high international prices.

The country’s petroleum product export volumes declined by a fourth to 11.3 mt in April-June from 15 mt in the corresponding period of last year as domestic fuel supplies took precedence amid the global supply crunch. Nonetheless, the exports surged nearly 40% in value due to the jump in international petroleum fuel prices.

Taking into account the overall oil, LNG, and petroleum product imports as well as fuel exports, the country’s net oil and gas imports rose 45.3% y-o-y in April-June to \$44.9 billion, the PPAC data shows. Energy imports are a major component of India’s overall imports, and any meaningful increase has ramifications for its trade balance, current account, inflation, and the rupee’s exchange rate, among others. **FULL REPORT ON**

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Banks mobilise \$17.4 billion via special FCNR(B) scheme

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 20

INDIAN BANKS have raised \$17.40 billion from overseas after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) unveiled a special window allowing lenders to mobilise fresh three- to five-year Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) — FCNR(B) — deposits until September 2026, a move aimed at boosting capital inflows, shoring up the rupee and strengthening foreign exchange reserves.

The mobilisation came 42 days after the RBI operationalised the special scheme on June 8, 2026. With two months and ten days left for the closure of scheme, banks are expected to raise over \$50 billion through the scheme. “The swap facility has seen avid interest and attracted

• What banks mobilised

TYPE	AMOUNT *
FCNR(B) Deposits	17,406
OFCBs	1,970
ECBs	1,342
Total	20,718

* IN USD MILLION; SOURCE: RBI

steady forex inflows since June 8,” the RBI said while releasing the figures as of July 17.

The special FCNR(B) dispensation is aimed at strengthening the country’s balance of payments and incentivising capital inflows, the RBI said. Following the outbreak of the West Asia conflict, the rupee depreciated and neared 97 per dollar, while foreign investors pulled out funds from the market amid a

surge in crude oil prices. The RBI used its forex reserves to prevent a sharper decline in the rupee’s value. On Monday, the rupee closed 17 paise down at 96.45 against the dollar.

The central bank has permitted banks to swap these deposits with the RBI at a concessional rate, effectively covering the entire hedging cost. By absorbing the hedging burden, the RBI has made FCNR(B) deposits a more attractive source of overseas funding for lenders.

Experts believe the steps announced may attract an additional \$50 billion to \$70 billion in foreign capital into Indian markets with banks offering higher interest rates of around 7% after considering the hedging sops.

FULL REPORT ON
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New series: Jun core sector growth 5%, iron ore output jumps 44%

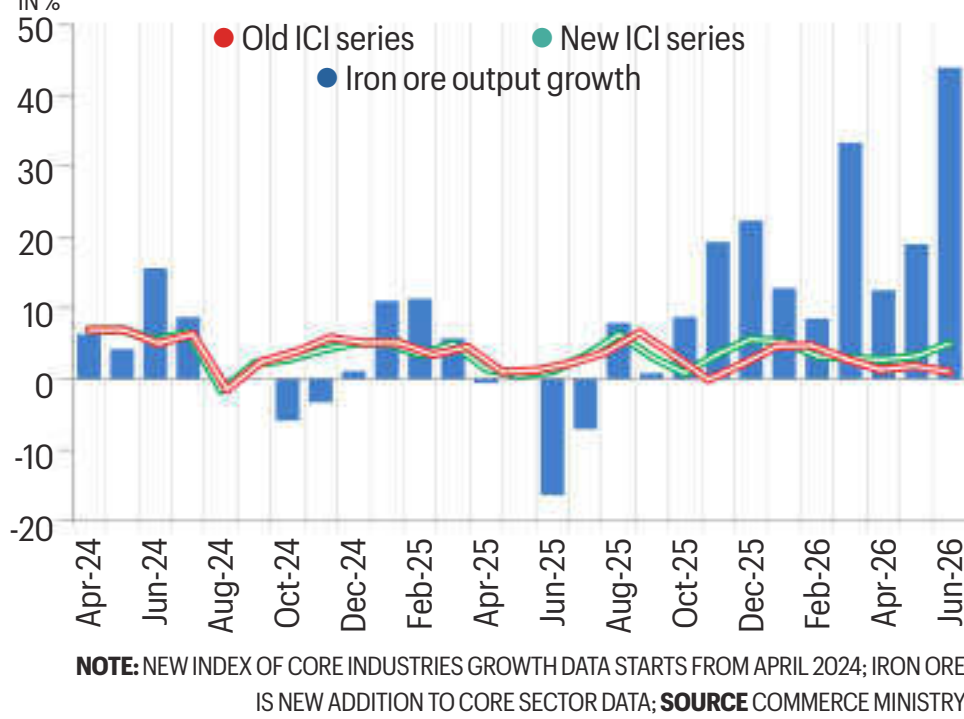
Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 20

THE COMMERCE ministry’s revised Index of Core Industries (ICI) surged to a five-month high of 5% in June. The inclusion of iron ore as the ninth sector was instrumental as its output was 43.9% higher compared to June 2025, according to data released Monday, with a low base effect responsible for this outsized rate of growth.

The new core sector data series — which has 2022-23 as the base year as against 2011-12 in the old one — continues the government’s overhaul of India’s official statistics. So far in 2026, the statistics and commerce ministries have already released updated data series for GDP, Consumer Price Index, Index of Industrial Production, Wholesale Price Index as well as the inaugural Output Producer Price Index and trial numbers for input PPI and an Index of Services Production. The new data series downgrades core sector growth in 2024-25 sharply to 4.3% from 6.9%. However, it has upgraded the figure for 2025-26 to 3% from 1.1%.

While iron ore only makes up 4.9% of the new Index of Core Industries, the 43.9% jump in its production in June was key to the entire core sector output ris-

• Old vs new: Core sectors, iron ore performance



ing the most in five months. The growth for May has been revised higher to 3.2% in the new series from a 1% under the old series.

Iron ore, whose output is estimated to have risen by 19% in May, has been added to the index due to its extensive industry use and significant contribution to industrial development. The other eight sectors part of the ICI are coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, fertilisers, steel, cement, and electricity.

Some of the other key changes in the revised core sector data include the use of gross

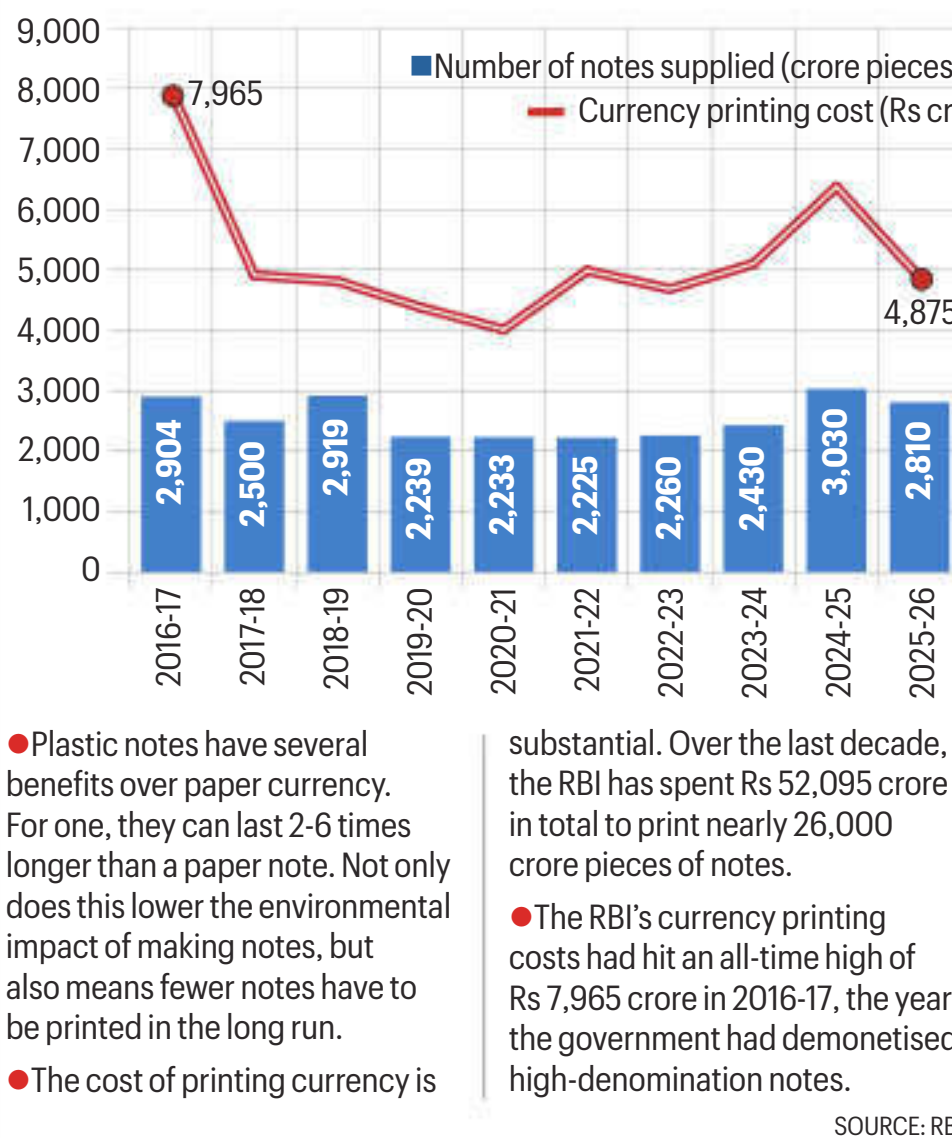
production data for compiling the steel index, the coal index including only ‘raw coal’ and not coal middlings and washed coal to eliminate double counting, among others.

Apart from iron ore, core sector growth in June was driven by a 9.8% rise in electricity generation, with the high temperatures and rainfall deficit boosting demand for power. The same sub-par monsoon helped raise coal output by 1.4% after three consecutive months of decline.

FULL REPORT ON
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• Plastic notes should lower RBI’s printing costs

The Bharatiya Reserve Bank Note Mudran Private Ltd (BRBNMPL), a wholly-owned subsidiary of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), last week floated a tender for polymer sheets that will be used for a trial project that will see the Indian central banks issue plastic notes for the first time.



No decision yet on increasing ethanol blending in petrol: Govt

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 20

AMID THE backlash on ethanol-blended petrol, the government on Monday informed Parliament that no decision has been taken on raising blending levels beyond the current 20%, and any decision to raise the blending levels will be taken only after detailed studies and stakeholder consultations. There is also no plan to make lower ethanol-petrol blends and pure petrol available at fuel stations.

“So far, no decision has been taken by the Government for increasing ethanol blending with petrol beyond 20%. Any future decision regarding higher ethanol blends will be taken only after detailed scientific and technical studies and consultations with all relevant stakeholders, including automobile manufacturers, Oil Marketing Companies and research institutions,” Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi informed Rajya Sabha.

India achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year and at present, the E20 fuel — 80



India achieved 20% ethanol blend in petrol last year. REUTERS

parts petrol and 20 parts ethanol — is the standard petrol variant across the country. There has been a public backlash over the E20 fuel, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear and tear in older vehicles whose engines were not designed for higher ethanol blends.

Gopi said that while the E20 fuel can reduce fuel economy by 3-5% in older vehicles whose engines are not designed for this blend, it is cleaner and superior in other performance parameters vis-a-

vis pure petrol and lower ethanol-petrol blends.

“With regard to efficiency, studies indicate that fuel economy depends on several factors, including driving conditions, driving habits and vehicle maintenance. Mileage depends on driving habits, tyre pressure, servicing and AC load far more than fuel type. Any reduction in fuel economy in certain older E10-designed vehicles is generally limited to about 3-5%, while E20 offers a higher octane rating, superior anti-knock characteristics, cleaner combustion and smoother engine operation,” the minister said.

On its part, the government has been attempting to allay fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would be marginal, and would be outweighed by the benefits like higher octane rating, superior anti-knock characteristics, faster combustion, better pickup, smoother acceleration and cleaner engine operation. The government has also consistently rejected claims that E20 fuel could damage engine components. **FULL REPORT ON**

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“ I just want the new generations to see my example as an opportunity – when you go down, you can rise again. This is my philosophy for my entire life.” RODRI, SPAIN MIDFIELDER ”

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Spain touched the ball over 400 times more than Argentina, a marker of their total hold on the game. The victors had 20 shots on goal, as against Argentina's two



Spanish players celebrate with the trophy after outclassing Argentina 1-0 in the FIFA World Cup 2026 final. La Roja were crowned champions for the second time. AP

On pass-masters, and the space-masters who came after



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 20

WITH HIS headmaster-like demeanour, Spain's manager Luis de la Fuente waited patiently to lay his hands on the most prized sporting trophy in the world. He was in no haste, perhaps because he knew the trophy would be his and the wondrous band he has assembled would remain in contention for the next four years; perhaps he is fascinated more by the journey than the destination, or maybe he knows his team is not yet finished piling trophies onto the federation's mantlepiece.

He, and the whole world, could see the tidings of a footballing dynasty that could rule the world for the next decade. The second Spanish dynasty of the century, and as artful and delightful as the previous iteration, the tiki-takians.

The route to the crown was flawless, steadily raising their tempo from a goalless draw against Cabo Verde to the re-

Spain, Rodri, and the argument that a second golden generation has already begun

If their backline is impenetrable, the midfield is unbreakable, and the forward line uncontainable when in full flow

morseless annihilation of a magnificent France to gently dismembering the fight and bravado of Argentina, the defending champions, the men of moments. In the post-match presentation, de la Fuente stressed on "being faithful to our idea of football" without ever directly detailing what that idea was. There is no clearly defined or perceptible ideology here, the way there was with tiki-taka during their reign. Perhaps their idea is amorphous, too broad to pin down to a specific act.

But their leitmotif is clear: to minimise the variables of knockout football and make themselves near-unbeatable, to wrap themselves in invincibility. To entirely suck the risk out of the game, not by refraining from attacking football and parking the bus, but by ensuring that everything is in order, the shape and structure, the creaks and crumples covered, like a freshly ironed suit.

To kill teams softly, to marinate them on a slow fire, draining their hope drip by drip. It's the most brutal murder, because they concede no chance of sur-

vival. They have not produced thrillers, because their game is fine-tuned to such precision that they avoid wild fluctuations. They have never been in a crisis, because their vision is not to wait for one but to avoid it altogether, through dynamism in pressing and clarity in thinking, passing and positioning.

If their backline is impenetrable, the midfield is unbreakable, and the forward line uncontainable when in full flow. The level of sustained concentration required to defend against them, attack them, or overpower their midfield is almost indecent. Their defence wore down Cristiano Ronaldo, Kevin De Bruyne, Kylian Mbappe, Michael Olise and Lionel Messi. Only once has their backline been breached in the

whole tournament. Only 43 shots have been attempted against them. The midfield outclassed all and sundry; the pack of forwards took turns to strike. Goals sprung from everywhere, they had seven different goal-scorers. Every match had a different hero, yet there is little arrogance or ego. They can't be conquered mentally, physically or tactically.

No theatrics needed

A flimsy argument could be raised that they don't thrill, that their game is bereft of flourishes, more opera than heavy metal, even with a spirit as blithe as Yamal's. The truth is they are so evolved that they need no theatrical embellishment or showmanship to assert their supremacy. They will be celebrated as a team that engaged the brain more than the soul, a connoisseur's delight rather than a layman's.

Watch closer, and there is a contained beauty in every stride they take. The half-turns of Dani Olmo, the torqued first touches of Yamal, the gorgeous pass-reading of Pau Cubarsi, the svelte, slick passing patterns,

their graceful control of emotions, the surreal serenity in times of crisis (if at all they face one), the geometric passing style has a Euclidean mastery to it.

There could have been more entertaining teams, more romantic ones. But maybe not a more perfect one. As perfect as the tiki-taka era, when they collected three trophies in four years. De la Fuente's group could match that, even surpass it, and transform into a footballing dynasty. The nucleus is still young, the average age is 26.2. The two most important cogs in the title triumph were 19-year-olds, Yamal and Cubarsi. They could rule football for a decade, with more talent still to spring from the vibrant youth academies of Barcelona, Atletico, Villarreal and Real Madrid (even though there was no Madrid player in the squad).

If the 2008-12 vintage, the team that post-modernised the game, had two pass-masters of virtuosic grandeur in Xavi Hernandez and Andres Iniesta, de la Fuente's batch had the irresistible Rodri, the team's ticking heartbeat. His stifling of Messi was a defensive masterclass.

Messi turned him once early on, but thereafter Rodri pushed him into an airless chamber, suffocating him like a boa constrictor, tightening his grip over the greatest player ever and making it harder and harder for him to breathe. If Xavi and co. were pass-masters, Rodri and friends are space-masters. He is a role model in his words as much as his deeds. "I just want the new generations to see my example as an opportunity – when you go down you can rise again. This is my philosophy my entire life," he said after the game. His advice to his players was simple: "We need to face them. We have to look into their eyes and see it. We win this game, and then life gives you the World Cup, or not."

In every sense, they could make a compelling case to be one of the greatest teams ever. The debates will no doubt escalate. The Brazil of 1970 is the romantic ideal. Or the French dazzlers led by Zinedine Zidane. Or Spain's own golden generation. De la Fuente's men belong rightly in that pantheon of greats, for the graceful efficiency with which they minimised the variables of knockout football and made themselves near-unbeatable. And their era is far from nearing its end.